By 2014, the global situation compelled India to conceptualize its foreign policy goals in a different way. It first had to recognize the greater multipolarity and uncertainty that characterized international affairs. Nations were combining on narrower issues rather than broad approaches. To a large extent, world affairs now looked like a global marketplace with less pre-conceptions and more transactions.

In this background, India set out to deliberately raise its global profile, consciously influence international gatherings and negotiations, purposefully increase high-level contacts and ambitiously invest in building linkages and connectivity. The primary objective was to consolidate its position in Asia. But, in parallel, India also made an effort to think beyond. Within Asia, obviously, the neighbourhood came first and the very act of inviting their leaders together in 2014 at the time of swearing in sent a clear message of change. In South Asia, India now became a votary of positive regionalism and expressed that through expanded commitments to connectivity and development projects. It did take into account the identity politics so deeply rooted in its periphery but calculated that structural linkages can compensate in the longer run. Given that most of these nations are democratic, the pressures of electoral cycles and competitive politics also had to be managed.

Predictably, Pakistan has posed a particular challenge in view of its continuing practice of cross-border terrorism. Combined with its resistance to connectivity, it is clearly not on the same page as the other states of South Asia. A more confident India has demonstrated boldness both ways: in a willingness to engage as underlined by a dramatic prime ministerial visit to Lahore, as well as in a determination to conduct cross-LOC and cross-boundary strikes when required. Afghanistan has also been brought much closer, politically and psychologically. The implementation of the Chabahar port project and the provision of security assistance to the Afghan military reflects this fresh approach.

In keeping with its growing interests and aspirations, there is also now a stronger feel for the extended neighbourhood. Where South-East Asia is concerned, the earlier Look East policy has been given greater teeth through stronger project implementation focus and turned into Act East. This has